FINTECH

Chime backer Lauren Kolodny bets on AI to revolutionize estate processing

Marina Temkin · 11:57 AM PDT · July 24, 2025

Lauren Kolodny, a partner at Acrew Capital, has always championed technology's power to democratize access to financial services for everyday people.

When the fledgling neobank Chime struggled to convince investors in 2016 that it could build a large business serving the working class, Kolodny was the only VC out of 100 Chime pitched who agreed to back the company, stepping in with a $9 million Series A extension when it was nearly out of money.

That bet paid off big time. Last month, Chime went public at a $14.5 billion valuation.

IMAGE CREDITS: ASPECT VENTURES

Kolodny, who appeared on the Forbes Midas List three years in a row, is still passionate about investing in tech solutions that help consumers maximize their resources.

She recently led a $20 million Series A investment in Alix, a startup that leverages AI to automate the estate settlement process.

Alix's founder, Alexandra Mysoor, realized the burden of executing a family estate after she offered to help her best friend settle her late mother's affairs. Mysoor told TechCrunch that it took her 900 hours and 18 months to complete tasks such as calling the bank to transfer assets, locating all the 401(k)s, canceling accounts, and distributing assets among family members.

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"I was shocked that this process was so hard," Mysoor said. "It's paper-driven. It's archaic. You're googling to-do lists that are not helpful. You're calling attorneys who might do a sliver of the work, and they cost thousands and thousands of dollars."

That experience gave Mysoor the idea that some of the most labor-intensive aspects of trust administration, including scanning and extracting data from documents, pre-populating complex forms, and communications with banks, can now be handled by AI agents.

When Kolodny met Mysoor and learned about the problem Alix was addressing, the issue resonated so deeply with the Midas List investor that she couldn't get it out of her mind.

Kolodny realized that even though economists are estimating that trillions of dollars will transfer to millennial and Gen Z generations over the next two decades, the paperwork surrounding estate settlement largely remains a burden on those grieving the loss of their parents.

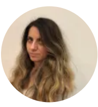
While some startups like Empathy provide assistance with closing accounts as part of their bereavement support, Kolodny discovered that no companies offered comprehensive, start-to-finish estate settlement services.

“How is it possible that there’s this messy problem that involves so much project management that there aren’t even meaningful services around?” Kolodny told TechCrunch. “It was this real aha moment for me. This is exactly the kind of problem that AI should be solving.”

Kolodny said that she believes Alix is among the first of many startups powered by AI that will democratize financial services and administrative processes, which were historically available only to the ultra-wealthy.

Alix’s fee structure is 1% of an estate’s value. However, for inheritances under $1 million, customers can expect to pay between $9,000 and $12,000, with the exact cost determined by the complexity of the estate.

Topics: acrew capital AI Chime estate planning Fintech lauren kolodny Startups



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Chime almost died in 2016, turned down by 100 VCs — today it IPO'd at $14.5B

Julie Bort — 10:23 AM PDT · June 12, 2025

One of the year's most anticipated IPOs took place on Thursday when neobank Chime raised $864 million in its IPO, pricing its shares at $27, which is above its [previously announced] range of $24 to $26. That gave it a starting market cap of about $9.8 billion.

While some would point out that this is far below its last private valuation of $25 billion, according to

PitchBook's estimates, shares opened at $42, putting it at $14.5 by midday in heavy trading, according to Yahoo Finance. It closed the day at $37 and about a $12 billion market cap. That's still well shy of it's yesteryear high, but it was a healthy response from retail investors all the same.

The hungry response is largely due to some impressive financials. Chime reported $1.3 billion in revenue in 2023 and $1.7 billion in 2024. Losses shrank from $203 million in 2023 to $25 million in 2024. It became profitable in its first quarter of 2025 with $13 million of net income on $519 million in revenue — although the company warns it may not stay in the black as it spends on growth.

Still, no founder journey is always up and to the right, and that has been especially true for Chime. The company had its share of struggles, like layoffs in 2022 and a fight with regulators in 2021 that forbade it from calling itself a "bank."

But the biggest struggle of them all was when it almost died before it even raised a Series B.

"We founded the company in 2012, and the first, really, five or six years was very difficult in terms of convincing investors to invest in the idea and the business. It was just way, way harder than I expected," co-founder Ryan King and the company's original CTO told TechCrunch (he's currently a board member and a principal shareholder).

Chime was almost out of money at that point, he said. He and co-founder and CEO Chris Britt still believed in the mission: an online bank experience, aimed at the working class, that was free for users, making its money on interchange fees. Chime, for instance, doesn't charge overdraft fees, and it offers credit-building tools like cash-secured "credit cards."

But VC after VC looked at the heavily regulated industry it was trying to disrupt, and its admittedly meager growth by that time, and passed.

King remembers reading a tech press article about how the founders of Robinhood pitched 50 to 75 investors, and only got a couple of term sheets, scoffing to himself, "I get 50 no's in a week," he said, smiling about it now.

CHIME CO-FOUNDER RYAN KING. IMAGE CREDITS:CHIME

So what happened to save Chime? A single seed investor said yes: Lauren Kolodny, then a partner at Aspect Ventures, today a co-founder of Acrew Capital. Kolodny led Chime's $9 million extension.

"She really took a bet on Chris and I, and believed in our passion and zeal and sort of attitude," he said. "It was the only term sheet we had at the time." She remained such a big supporter that Chime invited her to the podium to ring the opening bell at Nasdaq.

That check brought Chime's total raise to $21 million at the time. Britt and King would go on to raise about $2.65 billion as a private company, PitchBook estimates. A few years later it would be chased by renown VCs like Iconiq.

Meanwhile, Kolodny saved the company by buying in at 26 cents per share, according to the company's disclosure of share prices of its private rounds. So however many billions Thursday's valuation landed on, she clearly still wins. (Kolodny did not immediately respond to our request for comment.)

Yet, the icing on the cake for King came during the company's road show, where it was pitching institutional investors to buy its IPO shares.

While being asked for ID by the security guard in a white-marbled building that looked like a set from the HBO show "Billions," the guard saw Britt's Chime card in his wallet.

"And the security guard says, 'Oh, I see that Chime card.' And he winks at us," King said. The founders asked if he was a Chime customer and the guard replied, "Checking and savings, baby!" and gave the founders a high five.


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IMAGE CREDITS: NASDAQ

Iconiq VCs spent two years courting Chime and the firm isn't selling its stake

Julie Bort — 5:00 AM PDT · June 13, 2025

The VC tech world was abuzz on Thursday when neobank Chime successfully became a public company. Chime raised $864 million on its $27 share price, which popped big, opening at $43.

This wasn't the biggest IPO of the year. CoreWeave, for instance, raised $1.5 billion in March, and its first-day market cap hit around $14 billion, too. (Its share price and valuation has soared since then.)

However, Chime's cap table includes an absolute who's who of Silicon Valley investors, many of whom are publicly and privately celebrating the win for their portfolio company.

This includes Iconiq's Yoonkee Sull. He and his venture investing partner at Iconiq, Greg Stanger, spent two years watching and pursuing Chime before writing a check, Sull told TechCrunch.

Iconiq is, of course, well known in the Valley as the family office to some of the industry's most celebrated billionaires, like Mark Zuckerberg. With $80 billion of assets under management, it invests in everything from stocks to real estate, and also has a venture capital arm. Its portfolio includes Benchling, Canva, Databricks, Glean, Notion, and Ramp. If you've heard of a company, Iconiq probably has a stake.

Sull said that he and Stanger first met Chime co-founders Chris Britt and Ryan King in 2017. They even went to the Chime offices for the meeting, not the other way around. Iconiq's VCs tend to prefer outbound deals with well-vetted founders, rather than inbound pitch-to-us sessions.

Still, to have Iconiq come calling just a year after Britt and King's humbling 2016 was quite the turnaround. Chime was running out of cash in 2016. King had been desperate to raise and was turned down by over 100 VCs, he told TechCrunch. Lauren Kolodny, then a partner at Aspect Ventures, today a co-founder of Acrew Capital, saved the company with a $9 million Series A extension round.

Sull admits that that casual 2017 meeting "was early days at that point in time, but I think what they wanted to accomplish and do was crystal clear," Sull says of the founders. Chime positions itself as banking and credit-building resources for the average person and working class — the ironic opposite from Iconiq's bread-and-butter wealth management business.

As the VCs watched the founders over the next two years "deliver against the things that they said they would do," Sull says, Iconiq was convinced to elbow into Chime's oversubscribed $200 million Series D in 2019. Series D investors paid $5.22 a share, Chime disclosed in its S-1 filings.

"When we made our investment in 2019 there were quite literally a couple dozen other competitors going after a similar thesis or idea," Sull said. Iconiq chose Chime, and participated in follow-in rounds, because the investors thought the founders were more focused and didn't get distracted by "shiny new objects."

For follow-on rounds, Series E investors paid about $17, Series F was about $41 a share, and $69 for Series G, Chime disclosed. So even with a solid IPO, not all the private shares are above water yet.

Sull wouldn't comment on how much Iconiq paid for its stake, which is not large enough to be publicly disclosed. But he did say Iconiq didn't want to liquidate.

"We have our shares, and we're not selling in the IPO," he said. Existing shareholders, including employees, are now subject to a 180-day lock-up period, too.

Iconiq is one of many of Chime's backers taking a victory lap at Chime's graduation to become a public company. Investor Shawn Carolan, from

Menlo Ventures, wrote in his congrats blog post: "As with most consumer tech winners, what may have looked to some like an overnight success story was actually many hard years in the making."

Then there's Cathay Innovation, which led Chime's $15 million Series B in 2017 and happily sold 3.75 million shares in the IPO of its 15.3 million share stake. Series B shares were priced at 47 cents, Chime disclosed.

Correction: This story has been updated to correct an error in the price per share information for Series E, F, and G.

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